

Q I wish to upgrade my PC. My PC configuration is 1.5 GB of DDR2 667 MHz memory, ATI Radeon X1550 Series graphics card, Intel E4600 CPU, Asus P5KC Motherboard and 400 watt SMPS. I want to upgrade my memory and GPU first. I will also upgrade my processor but a few months down the line. My budget for the graphics card is Rs. 5,000 and for the memory is Rs. 3,500. Which brand is good and what sort of a performance increase can I expect with a memory upgrade? Should I change my PSU for my configuration? My budget for the processor is Rs. 8,000.

Ihsan Ibrahim

 The weakest points in your configuration is your CPU and GPU. You haven't mentioned what your usage pattern is, but I would recommend DDR2 800 MHz memory in a dual channel configuration if you're on a really tight budget or 1066 MHz memory if you can spend a thousand bucks more. Opt for two sticks of 2 GB each for a total of 4 GB. For the graphics card I suggest you invest in an NVIDIA GeForce 9600 GT-based graphics card. EVGA's 9600 GT is a good option. Expect to pay Rs. 6,000 for this – which is a steal in my opinion. Intel's E8400 (3.0 GHz), is a good processor for a powerful, multipurpose PC. It's a Wolfdale based dual-core processor with 6 MB of L2 cache and is priced at around the Rs. 8,000 mark. Expect a 10 percent increase in performance with your memory upgrade and a much higher increase in performance with the recommended CPU and GPU. Change your PSU; Corsair's VX 450 is a good buy at Rs. 3,500 and will power your PC.

Q I am planning to buy a new machine with an AMD Phenom X4 9550, JetWay HA-06, Seagate 1 Terabyte (32 MB Buffer) HDD, Sony 20 X SATA DVD writer and a 17-inch LCD monitor. I am a general home user although I play the odd game. Please suggest a suitable power supply and cabinet and also a good DVD writer apart from Sony.

Cyrus Chowbey

 Why don't you go with a Core 2 Duo E8400 instead? It is faster than the X4 9550 in all the tasks you've mentioned. If you want a quad core, Intel's own Q6600 will also be a better option. Both of these cost the same as the X4 9550. For a power supply I recommend a VIP 500 watt PSU which will cost you around Rs. 3,000. Look at the CoolerMaster 690 for a cabinet; it's a great looker and cools excellently. If you want a decent gaming experience with older games look at a graphics card – the GeForce 8600 GT is a good entry level chipset; it should be priced at the Rs. 3,500 mark. LG DVD writers are good alternatives to Sony and I personally feel they're more reliable.

Q I have decided to buy a camcorder that fits in a budget of 20k. Please let me know about the 3 models: Samsung's VP_DX103i, Sony's DCR-DVD610 and

Ask Away!
Want a tech product, but don't know how to go about buying it? E-mail agent001@thinkdigit.com with your complete contact details, and he might answer them here! Please note that Agent001 only answers purchase-related questions in this space.

Canon's DC310, their IS and recording medium. Would a 35x optical zoom be sufficient for shooting in the hill stations? Which of the above models fits the best for my purpose?

Chayan

 First of all let me say that I find HDD-based camcorders much better than disc- or tape-based ones. They are also compact in comparison. A 35x optical zoom is enough for most situations; and in any case camcorders with a higher zoom are rare and suitably price i.e. beyond your budget. Please use the camcorder you intend to buy to ascertain the effectiveness of its optical zoom; which for me is the most important factor when buying a camcorder for outdoor purposes.

Q I have planned to purchase Sony Ericsson's W595 cellphone. It's priced at Rs. 14,000. I want a mobile with good music solution. Can you suggest any other worthy mobiles around Rs. 14k to 15k?

Merbin Shyju

 It depends on what exactly you're looking for. If you want a feature-rich Symbian based cellphone then I would point you towards the Nokia N73 Music Edition. Else if you wanted an SE phone I'd suggest the K850i – which has a good camera and also great music quality. This should be priced at around the Rs. 15,500 mark and is superb for the price. The SE K800i/K810i phones are also good for you – they offer excellent music quality and a very good camera. These phones are cheaper and the K810i is actually priced around the Rs. 9,000 mark; meaning you can pick up an iPod Nano 4 GB with the remaining cash and get yourself a good PMP as well.

Q I am planning to buy a PC. It will be used for lots of business stuff, including the stock market monitoring etc. You see I am very fond of gaming also. I would like a gaming rig combined with a business power machine. Could you suggest a good configuration within a budget of around Rs 70,000?

Rohan Kumar

 Here's my recommendation:
Going for a quad core doesn't make sense unless you are willing to sacrifice on some other component and get an Intel Q9550 (2.83 GHz) processor which will cost Rs. 17,500. ■

PC Configuration

Components	My Suggestion	Price
Processor	C2D E8500 (3.16 GHz)	9,500
Motherboard	MSI P 45 Platinum	10,000
RAM	2 x 2 GB DDR2 1066 MHz (Kingston, Corsair)	5,000
Graphics Card	ZOTAC GeForce 9800GTX+ AMP!	12,000
Hard Drive	Seagate 1 TB 7200.11	6,800
Monitor	Dell SP 2208 WFP	15,000
Cabinet	CM 690	4,000
Power Supply	Corsair HX 520	6,000
		68,300